SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

CTHM GRADUATES IN THE WORKPLACE: A TRACER STUDY

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The Faculty of
College of Tourism and Hospitality Management

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CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Graduate outcomes-employment, job-program match, roles, and earnings-are globally recognized indicators of program quality in tourism and hospitality education. In the Philippine context, the continued growth of the tourism industry underscores the need to assess how effectively higher education institutions prepare graduates for employment. At the institutional level, this highlights the importance of conducting a tracer study on the graduates of the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management of Saint Michael College of Caraga (SMCC). Tourism is widely acknowledge as a major economic driver globally, with estimates indicating that it contributes about 10% of GDP and 10% of all jobs Tourism and Competitiveness (2025) In the Philippines, tourism is also a key pillar of the economy. It accounted for 6.2% of GDP in 2022, with 5.35 million jobs, and increased to 8.6% in 2023, with 6.21 million jobs Metrobank Wealth Insights (2023). These figures show that tourism not only generates income but also provides employment opportunities for millions of people, making graduate employability a critical concern for tourism and hospitality education institutions.

In addition, international evidence further underscore why graduate outcomes are treated as strong indicators of program quality. Outcomes systems and tracer initiatives

consistently track whether graduates are employed or pursuing further study because how quickly they transition into work, and whether their jobs are relevant to their training. For instance, UK outcomes reporting shows that graduates are in work or further study HESA (2025) Australia similarly monitors medium-term outcomes to assess employment patterns, job relevance, and further study pathways. These international approaches highlight a common emphasis: graduate outcomes serve as measurable proof of whether academic training translates into real labor market success.

Likewise, in the Philippines context, the same core indicators are emphasized through national-level efforts. The Social Research Centre (2025) found that national-level projects such as the 4th Philippine Graduate Tracer Study examine graduates' school-to-work transitions, time-to-employment, and job-relatedness across disciplines. Tutor et al. (2020) Consequently, Because the tourism and hospitality sector is growing, programs must ensure that graduates have the skills employers need. One way to track this is through a tracer study. A tracer study follows graduates after they finish school. It collects data on time-to-first-job, the match between job and training, income range, and the length of the job search. These data help schools adjust their curricula and strengthen internships and student support.

Evidence from other countries shows that tourism and hospitality education can be effective when aligned with industry needs. Tracer Study of Tourism-and-Hospitality Vocational Secondary Education in Jordan (2021) reported that 75% of vocational graduates in tourism and hospitality found work within six months. Third Tracer Study Report in Cambodia (2024) found that Cambodian graduates who participated in skills programs had an 80% higher chance of obtaining industry-related jobs. In the United Kingdom, Gannon (2020) reported that 78% of students who completed international internships felt more employable and developed intercultural skills. Putra et al. (2022) also showed that both technical and soft skills training helped students meet industry standards, with success rates ranging from 70% to 90%.

Local studies show similar results Simangca et al. (2022) found that many BHRST graduates from Bohol Island State University–Candijay Campus were employed in jobs related to their field of study. Likewise, Magboo-Campo (2025) in her study Employability Pathways Among Tourism Management Graduates: A Tracer Study, examined the employment type, job-program alignment, and career pathways of Tourism Management graduates and found that many were employed in positions related to their field of study. Abad et al. (2025) reported that 85% of hospitality management graduates secured jobs within six months, with 70% working in fields tied to their program. Jastia et al. (2023) found that 78% of BSHRM graduates from AIMS obtained jobs related to their training. Sotero (2024) showed that structured internships increased employment rates by 20%

compared to no internships. Still, some gaps remain. J. C. Punsalan et al. (2024) noted that while many tourism graduates found work within a year, some lacked strong interpersonal and problem-solving skills. Other studies Duplon (2025) confirmed that on-the-job training improves employability and eases workplace entry. Magboo-Campo (2025) , J. Punsalan et al. (2024), and Dungog and Cayunda (2025) showed that combining classroom learning with real-world experience improved career readiness by 15%–25% compared with traditional programs.

Despite these findings, there is a clear need to conduct this study because the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management (CTHM) of Saint Michael College of Caraga (SMCC) currently lacks systematic and updated data on the employment outcomes of its graduates. While tracer studies have been conducted in other institutions, no formal and institution-specific evidence exists that documents the employability, job-program alignment, positions, and salary levels of SMCC-CTHM graduates. This absence of empirical data limits the college's ability to objectively evaluate the effectiveness and relevance of its curriculum and training programs. The urgency of this study is further justified by the continuous growth of the tourism and hospitality industry, which demands graduates with industry-relevant skills and competencies. As SMCC continues to produce graduates for this sector, relying on informal feedback is insufficient for determining whether graduates are adequately prepared to meet current labor market demands.

Thus, this study is necessary to generate reliable, data-driven information that can guide curriculum enhancement, strengthen industry linkages, and support continuous quality improvement within the CTHM program.

This study is significant to the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management of Saint Michael College of Caraga because it will provide evidence-based information on the actual employment outcomes of its graduates. The results will help the department assess whether its curriculum, teaching methods, and training programs are aligned with the needs of the hospitality and tourism industry and identify areas for improvement. Current and future CTHM students will benefit by gaining a realistic picture of job opportunities, positions, and salary ranges after graduation. The findings will also guide the school administration in planning and policy-making, assist employers in understanding the competencies of SMCC-CTHM graduates, and serve as a useful reference for future researchers on tourism, hospitality education, and graduate employability.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

Tracer studies are widely used to assess the employability of tourism and hospitality graduates by examining how academic preparation, skills development, internship experiences, and the alignment of education with industry needs influence

employment outcomes. Related literature shows that curricula aligned with industry practices and supported by practical learning approaches enhance graduates' job readiness and ability to meet workplace expectations. Studies further emphasize that the development of both technical and soft skills, such as communication, teamwork, and problem-solving, plays a significant role in improving employment opportunities and career advancement. Internship or on-the-job training is also identified as a key factor, as it provides hands-on experience and industry exposure that facilitate graduates' transition into the workforce. Overall, tracer studies highlight the importance of aligning tourism and hospitality education with industry requirements to ensure graduates' competitiveness in the labor market.

Age

Age is commonly included in tracer studies because it helps explain where graduates are positioned in their career life cycle which may influence employment stability, job fit, and career development.

In support of this, Romano & Bautista (2025), the BS Hotel and Restaurant Management alumni of the University of Rizal System-Antipolo Campus mostly belonged to early adulthood age cohort, which is characteristic of the conventional age of completion of one's degree during (SY 2014-2016). Based on the age breakdown, most respondents

were in their mid-20s to late-20s, Moreover, the authors concluded that this age group represented a workforce actively exploring career development opportunities. Furthermore, this younger profile was associated with high employability because younger graduates were viewed as more adaptable, physically capable for service work, and more willing to accept entry-level opportunities in hospitality. Therefore, the graduates' age structure supported the conclusion that they were positioned for employment entry and advancement in HRM-related sectors.

Similarly, graduates from Notre Dame of Marbel University were identified in the 29–34 age bracket indicating, the respondents were mostly in 'mid-career' rather than 'newly graduated'. In addition, this distribution suggest they had worked for some time, which may explain higher employment levels. Notably, the older adults likely had better job stability and a better chance of getting jobs in line with their degree as they tend to have maturity, better skills and increased job confidence. Thus, the study emphasized that age influenced employment outcomes because mid-career graduates often demonstrate improved competencies and clearer career pathways in hospitality.

Internationally, comparable patterns have been observed. For instance, the Graduate Tracer Study conducted by Pacific Consulting Ltd. for the National University of Vanuatu (2021), many respondents were between their mid-20s and mid-30s during the survey. Moreover, This suggest the study captured early to mid-career graduates rather



than only recent completers. Consequently, this age range suggests respondents may have had additional maturity and work experience that influenced their employment situation and how they assessed the relevance of tertiary preparation in the Vanuatu labor market.

In the UNESCO-commissioned tracer study of tourism and hospitality vocational secondary education graduates in Jordan (2021), age was included as a demographic variable, although the summary findings emphasized that many graduates were relatively young, typical of secondary school graduates. Importantly, the report linked youthfulness to the observed low employment rate (11%), noting that a large majority (78%) were pursuing further education rather than working. Therefore, age is essential in interpreting school-to-work transition data because younger graduates may not yet be fully positioned for stable employment, which affects how employability outcomes are understood.

Gender

Gender is widely discussed in tracer studies because it may shape access to employment, type of work obtained, and advancement opportunities, especially in industries where roles and promotion pathways may be uneven**.** In line with this, Preciado (2022) conducted a tracer study involving graduates from Mindanao State University at Naawan

and examined workplace outcomes and gender gap. Results showed a clear gender divide in graduate employment, with male graduates reporting higher employment rates and slightly more favorable employment timelines than female graduates. Furthermore, the study noted that female graduates faced issues related to equal treatment, workforce equity, and access to managerial opportunities. Thus, gender remains a critical demographic variable when analyzing employability and equity outcomes in tracer research.

Similarly, Magboo-Campo, (2025) also profiled tracer study respondents by gender in examining tourism management graduate pathways. Female respondents significantly outnumbered male respondents, reflecting broader enrollment patterns in tourism programs. However, while female representation was higher and participation in the workplace was strong, employment outcomes between males and females were described as generally similar-though occupational pathways differed across sectors. Consequently, gender was still presented as influential in sectoral choice and career trajectories.

Moreover, In a tracer study of tourism and hospitality vocational graduates in Ethiopia (2021–2023), Feredegn et al. (2023) reported that males were somewhat more prevalent, while women were more likely to seek administrative and customer service roles, and men were more represented in technical or operational positions. Therefore,

Even when overall employment levels were high for both groups, the study gendered patterns in job placement and advancement.

Likewise, S. Ababio (2024) explored TVET graduate employability in Ghana and found that female graduates were the more numerous respondents but were comparatively unemployed in some technical disciples. The study further showed patterns where males were more likely to be employed in technical and managerial roles, while females were more concentrated in administrative and service-type positions. Therefore, tracer studies emphasize gender analysis as essential for identifying workforce patterns, opportunities, and equity issues.

Marital

Marital status (single, married, widowed) may influence employability because tourism and hospitality work often involves shifting schedules, long hours, and mobility demands. Santos and Mamaclay (2025), reported that being married was a critical predictor of employability for hostel operation graduates, reflecting employer perceptions regarding stability and flexibility. Furthermore, Gappi et al. (2025) found that single graduates were hired sooner because they were generally more willing to relocate and take challenging work that builds employability. Similarly, K. A. Ababio et al. (2024) found that unmarried TVET graduates in Ghana were more mobile and adaptable to job demands, while married

graduates faced challenges balancing family responsibilities with workplace demands, which may limit options in competitive tourism services.

Year Graduated

Year graduated is not only a marker of time; it often reflects the curriculum version, institutional improvements, and labor market context that can share graduate outcomes. Graduation year refers to the academic year students complete their degree and receive their qualification. It also reflects curriculum strengths and how preparation aligns with hospitality labor needs. Some studies suggest graduation year affects job prospects. For example Australia Pacific Training Coalition (2021) stated that tourism and hospitality graduates from 2020 to 2021 had better chances of (Australia Pacific Training Coalition, 2021)employment than preceding cohorts due to stronger job training, improved linkages, and tourism recovery after the pandemic. Coast (2023) similarly noted that recent graduates were more likely to find employment, emphasizing competency-based training and collaborations with tourism and hospitality employers.

In line with this findings, Cerdeña et al (2023) studied hotel management graduates from Batangas State University JPLPC-Malvar Campus (FY 2021–2022) and found that recent graduates obtained jobs faster due to improved coursework and stronger industry connections. Maraña et al. (2024)) also reported that newer batches of

LSU Sinaloan BSHRM graduates (2014-2021) had better job fit and more job offers than older cohorts. Collectively, these findings suggest that graduation year can shape outcomes because curricula evolve alongside industry requirements.

Job search duration

Job search duration refers to the time graduates spend seeking employment after graduation, often measured in months until the first job is obtained. Posadas et al. (2021) categorized job search duration into “less than a month,” “1-6 months,” “7-12 months,” and “more than a year” when analyzing teacher education graduates. Tutor et al. (2020) similarly noted that young Filipino graduates typically take about three to four months to find work, measuring duration by months spent actively seeking employment. Grace P. Ganiera (2024) determined time-to-employment by calculating the proportion of BSOA graduates who obtained employment within one to three months, using this as an indicator of labor market responsiveness indicator, including evidence from nursing and allied health contexts Austria (2023) Dzomeku et al. (2024)

Additionally, Magboo-Campo (2025) reported that most BSTM graduates obtained their first job within three months (56.9%), and 18.6% within six months, suggesting favorable employability and strong labor demand in tourism and hospitality. Grace P. Ganiera (2024) also observed short time-to-employment patterns among BSOA

graduates. Overall, these findings support the value of including job-search duration in the SMCC-CTHM tracer study to evaluate graduate transition speed and institutional job placement effectiveness.

Employment Status

Employment status refers to whether graduates are employed, unemployed, or self-employed, and may further classify work as permanent, contractual, or part-time. Posadas et al. (2021) identified employment status categories such as permanent and part-time/contract positions and related these to income, sector, and job search duration. Reyes et al. (2025) also considered whether graduates were employed in teaching or non-teaching roles and whether work aligned with training. Other tracer studies show many graduates enter the workforce but often in mixed job security conditions Hospitality-specific tracer studies, such as in Kalinga State University, also report high employment rates Guwen and Ann Karen (2024)

Supporting these patterns, L. Simangca et al. (2022) found that 86.3% of BHRST graduates were employed, mostly in hospitality and service sectors; among employed graduates, 37.3% held regular/permanent positions and 28.4% held contractual roles. Magboo-Campo (2025) similarly reported that most BSTM graduates were working in degree-related roles, while a small group remained self-employed or unemployed. Taken



together. These findings support employment status as a major indicator of program success and justify the SMCC-CTHM tracer focus on employability, job security, and job-field alignment.

Employment Type

Employment type refers to whether graduates enter permanent, contractual, part-time, or self-employment roles. Ocampo et al. (2025) conducted a tracer study of Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management graduates from 2021 to 2023 and reported that graduates were employed in different employment types within hospitality-related industries. The study showed that graduates held positions at the rank-and-file, supervisory, and managerial levels, indicating variation in the nature of employment obtained after graduation. Melchor et al. (2025) reported that many Mindoro State University BSHM and BSTM graduates obtained work, though many were contractual and entry-level. Lagman (2025) found that 83.14% of Gordon College BSTM graduates were employed, commonly in tourism-related positions, and noted self-employment as a sign of entrepreneurial movement. Cerdeña et al. (2023) also reported many BSHM were “gainfully employed,” often connected to family businesses or hospitality establishments. Internationally, Semini (2024) found graduates in mixed employment types, suggesting early career work is often transitional or flexible.

Job Program Alignment

Job program alignment refers to how closely graduates' jobs match their tourism or hospitality degree training. Roma (2021) investigated assessment and curriculum practices in tourism and hospitality education and found that academic programs must reflect industry-required competencies to remain relevant. The study emphasized that aligning curriculum content and assessment methods with industry expectations helps ensure that graduates acquire skills applicable to professional practice in the hospitality and tourism sector. Lagman (2025) reported that many BSTM graduates were employed in roles directly relevant to tourism expertise, describing employability outcomes as "very satisfying". Melchor et al. (2025) noted graduates worked across multiple industries, showing both aligned and non-aligned pathways. Magboo-Campo (2025) found graduates held varied job titles but valued academic support and highlighted the importance of continuous alignment with evolving industry demands.

From the employer perspective, job-program alignment depends on competency match, especially communication, customer service, and problem-solving Ngoepe and Wakelin-Theron (2023) In addition, transferable skills enable graduates to move across sectors Stangl et al. (2024)



However, alignment challenges remain. Fufa et al. (2021) reported that fewer than half of employed graduates from Holeta Polytechnic College worked in degree-related roles, suggesting misalignment is a persistent concern in tourism and hospitality education.

Perception of Job Preparation

Perception of job preparation reflects how graduates evaluate whether their education prepared them for real workplace demands. Dalangin (2023) examined graduates attributes and workplace readiness and found that students perceived themselves to be prepared for employment based on the skills and competencies developed during their academic program. The study reported that job-specific skills, personal attributes, and workplace competencies were key factors influencing graduates' perceived level of job preparation. Across tourism and hospitality programs, effective preparation is linked both technical skills and soft skills Hussain et al. (2024) Mari et al. (2023) measured curriculum relevance across knowledge and technical skills, communication, human relations, leadership, research, and information and communication technology J. Punsalan et al. (2024) found that cognitive, communication, leadership, interpersonal, and information technology skills-were rated as very helpful by BSTM graduates and recommended more skills-based subjects and stronger OJT. Pepito et al. (2025) found graduates curriculum relevance and pointed to food and beverage

management, bartending, and housekeeping as important in their present work. Connecting employment outcomes to strong school-industry linkages. Mesa (2023) also indicated structured interventions improve perceived readiness. Evidence from soft-skills training initiatives supports this, noting improved confidence in workplace demands ScholarWorks@GVSU and Colaco (2024) Overall, the literature suggests hands-on training and exposure strengthen graduates' confidence and perceived preparation.

Job-relevant skills

Job-relevant skills are competencies graduates apply directly in the workplace. De La Cruz (2025) offers a complementary tracer perspective by arguing that Hospitality Programs must deliberately expose student to HRM-related task, communication activities, and structured skills-building exercise so that graduates are prepared for real workplace conditions. Based on graduates' feedback that the skills and knowledge provided by their institution were beneficial to their current line of work, frames curriculum enhancement as directly linked to the specific job-relevant skills that graduates are required to apply in hospitality and tourism settings. Melchor et al. 2025) noted management, communication, and service were considered useful while ICT and financial skills emerged as areas needing further improvement. Mari et al. (2023) assessed the curriculum's relevance across knowledge/technical, communication, human relations, leadership, research, and ICT at Batangas State University, showing that the goal of

hospitality programs is to give graduates a wide range of skills that enhance employability. J. Punsalan et al. (2024) emphasize cognitive, communication, leadership, interpersonal, and information technology skills they learned in college as "very helpful" in their current situation. Pepito et al. (2025) highlighted operational competencies food and beverage management, bartending, and housekeeping emphasize communication and interpersonal skills, which they deemed the most significant soft skills. Magboo-Campo (2025) also noted digital skills gaps. Employer-focused literature confirms strong demand for teamwork, reliability, communication, and problem-solving. Ghani et al. (2025) other studies link dispositions and cognitive strengths to skill application. Subia et al. (2022) highlight critical thinking and financial management needs. Maniram (2022) international evidence also highlights language communication competence as key for adaptability. Ren et al. (2023) and Gevana and Tan (2021) further found hospitality students view problem-solving, communication, and interpersonal skills as most essential.

Employment Satisfaction

Reflects graduates' contentment with pay, growth, and working conditions. Chen et al. (2023) Pepito et al. (2025) reported that many graduates were satisfied with their salaries and wages and recognized the career challenges present in the hospitality industry. Magboo-Campo (2025) found graduates appreciated university support but noted limited international employment opportunities, suggesting satisfaction with local

opportunities alongside recognition of global constraints. Abad et al. (2025) emphasized that tracer data can be used to evaluate satisfaction, preparation relevance, and guide program improvement. Overall, satisfaction tends to be stronger when graduates apply training in work and benefit from industry linkages.

Perceived Career Growth

Perceived career growth refers to graduates' sense of progress through promotions, increased responsibility, and higher pay. Yoopetch et al. (2021) show this pathway in hospitality-related service settings by linking learning/knowledge and satisfaction to performance, and then demonstrating that employee performance positively affects career growth. Putra et al. (2022) found graduates perceived stronger career growth when they could apply communication, problem-solving, and professional attitudes to more complex roles. A vocational tracer study in Albania reported high employment and satisfaction among tourism and hospitality graduates, with many aiming for higher wages and business ownership. Furthermore, career adaptability and optimism influence intentions to remain and progress Wang et al. (2024). While language competence supports advancement in international contexts Ren et al. (2023)

Consistent with this perspective, Duldulao (2025) found most BS Hospitality Management (BSHM) graduates of the University of La Salette, Inc., from the year 2019–

2023, and revealed that the vast majority of the participants were working and believed that their jobs were in line with their degree. The authors observed that graduates' recognition of career development or growth was associated with promotion opportunities, professional development, and perceived alignment between academic preparation and sport work demands. Nonetheless, the authors recommended that further enhancement of the curriculum might help graduates pursue positions in higher levels of responsibility, advancement, and longevity. Similarly, Diaz and Maramento (2023) reported most graduates were employed in hospitality-related roles, though many were self-employed or in small enterprises, describing current work as a "stepping stone" toward higher pay and better roles.

Job Search Pathways

Job search pathways refer to the methods and channels graduates use to find work, shaped by both institutional support and labor market conditions. International tracer studies indicate that tourism and hospitality graduates often rely on both formal and informal job search mechanisms. Hoof (2022) provide strong support for job search pathways by showing that how systematically and effectively job seekers move through the search process conceptualized as Job Search Quality (goal establishment & alignment, emotion regulation & persistence, and learning & improvement)-is linked to both employment outcomes and employment experience. Specifically, higher job search

quality predicted a greater likelihood of becoming reemployed and quicker reemployment (e.g., positive associations with later employment status and negative association with unemployment duration), and it was also strongly related to better employment-quality indicators among those reemployed, including higher perceived fit with the new job and higher job satisfaction. Mehari et al. (2024) reported that graduates in Ethiopia used personal networks, job postings, and training-related connections. Skills for Jobs (2023) similarly found that personal networks played a major role in Albania's vocational graduate transitions.

Related findings were reported by Mari et al. (2023) emphasized that on-the-job training, career fairs, faculty referrals, and individual applications influenced graduates' first employment. In addition, Matulin (2024) compared graduates with international versus local internship experience and reported that overseas internship graduates described more favorable outcomes, including employment abroad or degree-related work. Babaran Jr. (2025) further noted that a web-based alumni employability platform improved access to job opportunities and helped institutions monitor trends and enhance career services.

Employment Challenges

Employment challenges include job mismatch, underemployment, precarious work conditions, and skills mismatch Caria et al. (2024) show that in low and lower-middle income urban labour markets, jobseekers and firms are held back mainly by information gaps about skills and jobs, search and recruitment cost, weak networks, and hiring frictions. They find that giving firms and workers credible information about workers skills consistently improves employment-by about 3 percentage points, with effects lasting up to four years-while reducing search costs helps constrained jobseekers in the short term. Stemele (2022) reported that tourism and hospitality graduates faced limited job availability, competition from experienced workers, and acceptance of low-wage or seasonal roles, highlighting skill expectation gaps between training and employers. Sufi (2024) framed employability in a VUCA context, (volatile, uncertain, complex and ambiguous) nothing rapid technological and market changes and emphasizing weak industry-academe partnerships as a risk. Hospitality employment volatility was further illustrated by evidence linking job insecurity to turnover intention during COVID-19 Yin et al. (2022).

At the graduate level, Diaz and Maramento (2023) found many graduates took non-degree-related jobs due to job availability and relevance issues. (Sabando et al. (2022) also observed that not all graduates were employed, and those employed often



entered entry-level or non-competency-aligned roles, with some experiencing wait periods due to labor market conditions or feeling unprepared.

Placement Service Satisfaction

Refers to how graduates rate institutional support such as career planning, job placement assistance, and readiness training. Otache and Edopkolor (2022) found that work placement learning (WPL) directly improves employability and that this effect is largely channeled through higher student satisfaction, stronger commitment, and better academic achievement, which each have strong positive effects on employability. Their results suggest that placement are most effective as an employability "pipeline" when they are meaningful, well-supported, and structured to create positive learning experiences that employers can clearly recognize Otache and Edopkolor (2022) Mehari et al. (2024) assessed employability and satisfaction with institutional support in Ethiopia, linking perceptions of relevance, service value, and exposure to work-based experiences with satisfaction. Feredegn (2023) similarly highlighted academic advising, co-op training, and networking as valuable supports.

In the Philippines, placement-related satisfaction often appears as a graduate feedback about program quality and support services. Comicho and Apangchan-Laurel (2023) emphasized graduate input as a basis for curriculum and institutional

improvements, including industry linkages and support services. Sabando et al. (2022) also reported graduates identified program strengths and support components that helped them prepare for employment and job acquisition processes.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

This research study is based on two major theories: The Human Capital Theory and Employability Theory, both of which explain how graduates' characteristics, skills, and educational experiences influence their employment outcomes. The Human Capital Theory, advanced by Gary Becker and Theodore Schultz (1964) posits that both individuals and societies benefit from investing in education, training, and skill development. Individuals who invest in these areas become more productive and are more likely to access better job opportunities. In essence, formal education equips people with the knowledge and competencies needed to obtain and sustain decent employment and to increase earning over time.

In this study, graduates' profiles (year of graduation, civil status, sex, and age) serve as predictors of employability outcomes because these variables reflect conditions that can shape how graduates convert their education and skills into employment: year of graduation may indicate how current a graduate's competencies are with industry needs (recent training versus skills that may need updating), age may relate to work

maturity, adaptability, and possible exposure to workplace demands, sex may influence opportunities and job matching in tourism and hospitality due to contextual workplace practices and role access, and civil status may affect employability through differences in mobility, time availability, and work–life constraints, especially in an industry where shifting schedules and service demands are common.

Employability Theory, as explained by Yorke & Knight (2004.) emphasizes that employability depends not only on academic knowledge but also on personal attributes, transferable skills, and contextual factors. Graduates need competencies such as communication, interpersonal, problem-solving, entrepreneurial, and critical thinking skills. These abilities help graduates succeed and adapt in tourism and hospitality workplaces. Moreover, The theory also stresses that employability continues to develop, depending on individual action and how well the educational experience aligns with the needs of future employers. Thus, the graduate profiles variables (independent variables) are linked to employability outcomes (dependent variables).

1.4 Schematic Diagram

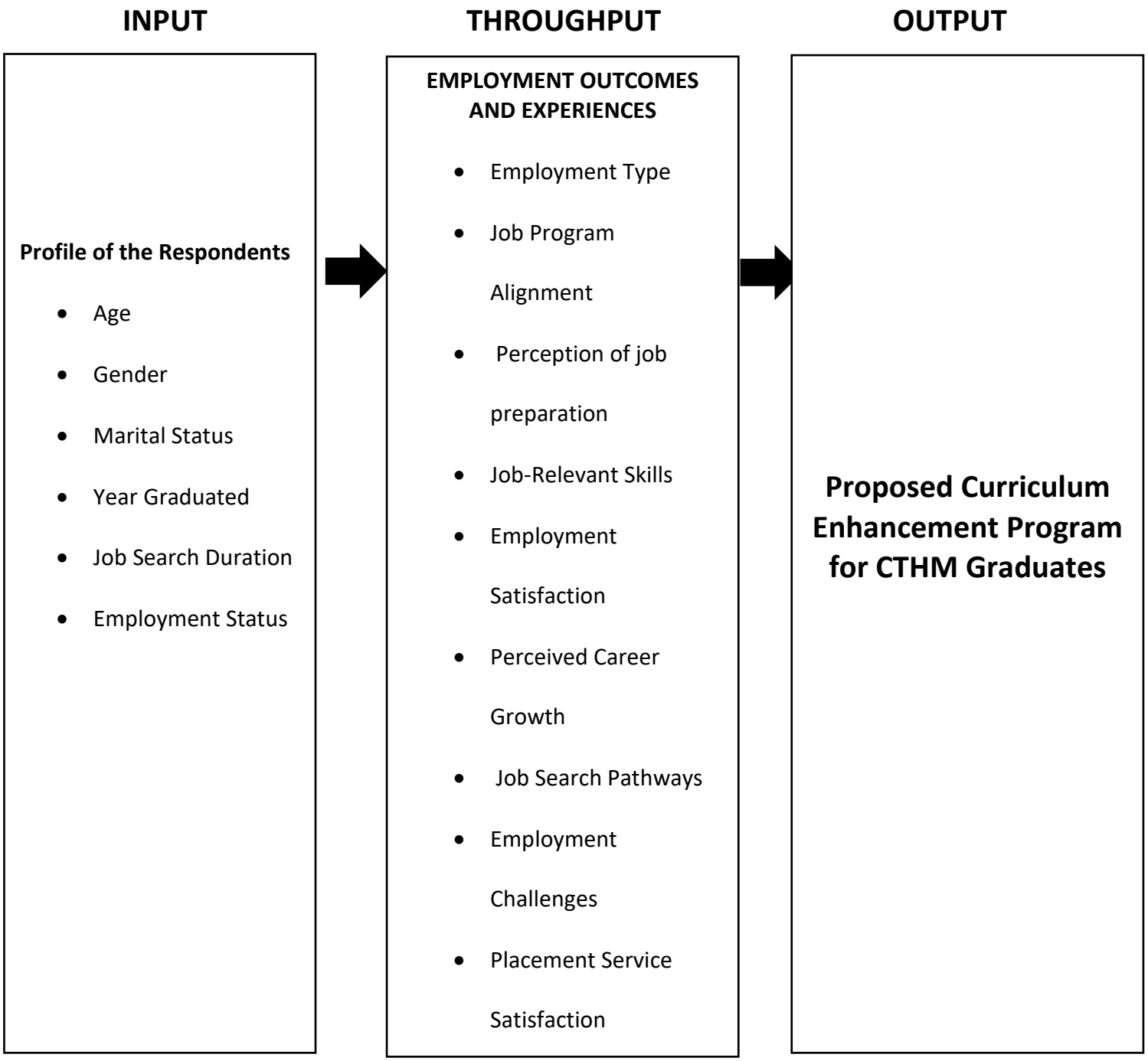


Figure 1. The Schematic Diagram presents the connection between the study variables.



1.5 Statement of the Problem

The study examines the satisfaction, career paths, and application of skills and knowledge gained from the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management at Saint Michael College of Caraga, focusing on graduates from the 2022–2023, 2023–2024, and 2024–2025 batches. It also investigates their demographics, employment characteristics, and the relevance of their degree to their current jobs.

1. What is the profile of the CTHM graduates in terms of:

   1.1 Age;

   1.2 Gender;

   1.3 Marital Status;

   1.4 Year Graduated;

   1.5 Job Search Duration; and

   1.6 Employment Status?

2. What are the employment outcomes and experience of the CTHM graduates in terms of

   2.1 Employment Type;

   2.2 Job-Program alignment;

2.3 Perception of job preparation;

2.4 Job-relevant Skills;

2.5 Employment Satisfaction;

2.6 Perceived career growth;

2.7 Job search pathways;

2.8 Employment Challenges; and

2.9 Placement service satisfaction?

3. Are there significant differences in the employment outcomes and experiences of CTHM graduates when they are grouped according to their profile variables (age, gender, marital status, year graduated, job search duration, and employment status)?

4. Based on the findings of the study, what curriculum enhancement program can be proposed for CTHM graduates that is responsive to their employment outcomes, employment experiences, and identified needs?

1.6 Hypothesis

There is no significant relationship between the employment status and skills learned among the respondents.

1.7 Definition of Terms

The following terms are operationally defined as they pertain to the profiles, employment outcomes, and experiences of CTHM graduates.

Employment Challenges - refer to the difficulties and barriers experienced by graduates in finding a job or adjusting to their work, such as lack of experience, job mismatch, competition, or limited opportunities.

Employment-Satisfaction - refers to the level of contentment of graduates with their current employment, including their job role, work environment, salary, and benefits.

Employment Status - refers to the respondent's ability to express their thoughts verbally in a workplace.

Employment Type - In this study, employment type refers to the kind of work arrangement of the graduates, such as full-time, part-time, contractual, project-based, or freelance.

Gender - In this study, gender refers to how the graduates identify themselves (e.g., male, female, or other gender identity) as indicated in the survey.

Job Program Alignment - refers to the extent to which the graduates' current job is related or matched to the academic program they completed.

Job Search Duration - refers to the length of time (in months or years) it took for graduates to find their first job after graduation.

Job Search Pathways - refer to the methods and channels used by graduates to find employment, such as online applications, referrals, school placement services, walk-in applications, or social media.

Job-Relevant Skills - refer to the knowledge, technical skills, and soft skills that graduates gained from the program and use in their current job.

Marital Status - refers to the civil status of the graduates, such as single, married, separated, widowed, or in a registered partnership.

Perceived Career Growth - refers to graduates' views on their opportunities for promotion, professional development, and long-term advancement in their chosen career.

Perception of Job Preparation - refers to how graduates 'rate or feel about how well their academic program prepared them for the responsibilities and demands of their job.

Placement Service Satisfaction - refers to how satisfied graduates are with the school's assistance in job placement, such as career guidance, job fairs, referrals, and linkages with employers.

Sex - refers to the biological classification of the graduates as male or female, based on what is recorded at birth.

Year Graduated - refers to the specific year in which the graduates completed their academic program and were officially conferred their degree.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter will discuss the research design, research locale, research respondents, and research instrument that will be used in the study. It will also explain the ethical standards, data-gathering procedures, and statistical treatment that will be employed.

2.1 Research Design

The researchers will use a quantitative method, specifically a survey questionnaire, to determine the employment outcomes and experiences of graduates from the Saint Michael College of Caraga College of Tourism and Hospitality Management (SMCC-CTHM). The study will focus on CTHM graduates from the identified batches and will gather data on their profile (age, gender, marital status, year graduated, job search duration, and employment status), as well as on key employability indicators such as employment type, job–program alignment, perception of job preparation, job-relevant skills, employment satisfaction, perceived career growth, job search pathways, employment challenges, and placement service satisfaction. This quantitative approach, carried out through structured surveys, is appropriate because it allows the researchers to obtain measurable data from a larger number of graduates and to examine patterns and differences in employment outcomes when they are grouped according to their

profile variables. The survey questionnaire will be a researcher-modified instrument anchored on the tracer studies of Simangca et al (2022) and Magboo-Campo (2025), and it will undergo reliability and validity testing to ensure that the items accurately capture the intended variables and yield consistent, dependable results for analysis.

2.2 Research Locale

The study will be conducted at Saint Michael College of Caraga (SMCC), a private Roman Catholic higher education institution administered by the Roman Catholic Diocese of Butuan and located in Brgy. 4, Atupan St., Nasipit, Agusan del Norte. Established in 1948, SMCC is one of the long-standing institutions in the area that offers programs aimed at preparing students for professional and industry needs.

The study will focus on the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management (CTHM), the department that implements the Bachelor of Science in Tourism Management (BSTM) and Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management (BSHM) programs. CTHM is a suitable research locale because it provides direct access to the target graduates and relevant records needed for the tracer study.

CTHM also develops student through a balance of classroom instruction and practical training, including laboratory activities and internships that expose students to real work settings. This approach helps build service competence, technical skills, and

professional confidence aligned with tourism and hospitality industry standards, making SMCC-CTHM an appropriate setting for examining graduates' employability outcomes.

2.3 Research Environment, population, and sample

This study will be conducted at Saint Michael College of Caraga (SMCC), Brgy. 4, Atupan St., Nasipit, Agusan del Norte, specifically in the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management (CTHM). This research setting is appropriate because it is where the graduates completed their academic programs, and it enables the researcher to access graduate records and alumni contact information necessary for the conduct of the tracer study.

The population of the study consists of all graduates of the Bachelor of Science in Tourism Management and Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management programs under CTHM within the graduation years covered by the study.

The sample will include graduates who meet the study's criteria, are reachable through available records, and are willing to participate. Purposive sampling will be utilized because the study requires participants who can provide first-hand and relevant information regarding their employment status, work experiences, and employability outcomes. Potential participants will be identified through official school records and/or the CTHM alumni list, and only those who provide informed consent will be included in the final survey.

Table 1.

Respondents of the study

School Year	Population				Sample					
	BSHM		BSTM		BSHM		BSTM			
	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Male	Female	Total F	Percentage
S.Y. 2022-2023	17	35	9	26	11	23	6	17	57	34.8
S.Y. 2023-2024	19	27	1	15	13	18	1	10	42	25.6
S.Y. 2024-2025	24	23	5	47	16	15	3	31	65	39.6
TOTAL	**60**	**85**	**15**	**88**	**40**	**56**	**10**	**58**	**164**	**100.0**

Table 1 shows the distribution of respondents involved in the study. Specifically, Bachelor of Science in Tourism Management and Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management students at Saint Michael College of Caraga.



2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

Research Instrument

The research instrument will be a researcher-modified tracer study questionnaire to gather data from graduates of the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management (CTHM) at Saint Michael College of Caraga. This instrument is anchored on the tracer studies of Simangca et al. (2022)and Magboo-Campo (2025), which served as guides in organizing the questionnaire and identifying the key employability areas typically covered in tracer research. Because the complete survey items were not presented in the cited studies, the researchers constructed the questionnaire items based on the variables and indicators discussed in the literature and aligned them with the present study. The questionnaire was further improved by rewriting items for clearer understanding, removing questions that do not apply to the local context, and adding or adjusting items to reflect the actual work experiences of tourism and hospitality graduates.

The questionnaire is divided into three sections. Part I collects the respondents' profile, including age, sex, marital status, year graduated, employment status, and the time it took to obtain the first job after graduation. Part II covers employment information, specifically the type of employment and the nature of employment. Parts III–X measure the employability indicators, namely job–program alignment, job preparation,

job-relevant skills, employment satisfaction, perceived career growth, job search pathways, employment challenges, and satisfaction with placement services. These indicators will be rated using a four-point Likert scale (4–Strongly Agree, 3–Agree, 2–Disagree, 1–Strongly Disagree). An open-ended question is also included to allow graduates to share suggestions for improving the CTHM curriculum; these inputs will help guide the development of the Proposed Curriculum Enhancement Program.

To ensure that the instrument is sound and appropriate, it will be submitted to the research adviser and selected experts for content validation to check its clarity, relevance, and alignment with the study objectives. It will also undergo pilot testing among a small group of CTHM graduates who will not be included in the final respondents. The pilot-test results will be used for reliability testing (internal consistency) and for revising any unclear or ambiguous items before the questionnaire is administered to the final respondents.



Statistical Treatment

In presenting, analyzing, and interpreting data, the researcher used the following statistical test, namely.

Frequency and Percentage – This tool used to answer SOP 1, in determining the profile of the respondents.

Weighted Mean - This tool used to answer SOP 2 and 3, in determining the challenges and preparedness of college students for internship.

Pearson's r Correlation – It was used to answer SOP 4, in determining the relationship among the profile of the respondents, challenges and preparing for internship in area of preparedness.

Spearman rho Correlation – It was used to answer SOP 5, in determining the relationship between challenges in preparing for internship and the area of preparedness among college students.

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

A. Protection of Intellectual Property Rights

This study respected intellectual property rights by keeping respondents' names private throughout the analysis. All secondary data and existing literature had been

correctly cited, honoring the intellectual property of others while protecting the researcher's own contributions.

B. Informed Consent

The respondents will be informed of the graduates of the Bachelor of Science in Tourism Management and the Bachelor of Science in Hospitality Management programs from Saint Michael College of Caraga. The respondents underwent a brief orientation conducted by the researchers to better understand the study's purpose and the potential benefits and risks before agreeing to participate. The respondents will be informed of their right to withdraw from the study at any time without any explanation. During the orientation, a written consent form was distributed to each respondent to ensure they fully understood their rights.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality

The personal information gathered, including respondents' demographics, was kept entirely secret and only utilized after respondents completed a form giving their informed consent. To protect responders' identities, all records are anonymous. The researchers were responsible for distributing the surveys to ensure that the answers remained private. Researchers kept the key that linked identifying numbers to

responders safe. During the survey, all data were kept safe and secure, preserved, and used solely for research, ensuring respondents' privacy was always protected.

D. Voluntary Participation and freedom to Withdraw

Participation in the study was voluntary. Respondents in the survey were informed of their right to withdraw without any negative consequences. No animals were involved in this study; therefore, the consideration of alternatives to animal use was not applicable.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

To create a secure and supportive study environment, the researchers treated the respondents with respect and professionalism. If any hazards were identified, respondents were referred to appropriate support services, such as the clinic and the Guidance Office, to ensure their safety and health throughout the research process. After participants finished, the researchers held a debriefing session to ensure no one was physically, mentally, or emotionally harmed during the study. The study did not include animal participants; thus, the 3Rs principles of replacement, reduction, and refinement were not relevant.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge

This study contributed to a better understanding of the challenges faced by CTHM students and their level of preparedness for upcoming internships. The study's findings were available upon request by the respondents. The study focused on improving the program and was based on its results.



G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

Respondents we will be selected using clear, fair inclusion criteria, ensuring that the selection process aligned with the study's goals. People from different backgrounds were included honestly and without bias.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy

Data collection and analysis will be conducted using standardized methods to ensure accurate and reliable results. Initially, the researchers submitted a formal request to the school registrar to obtain the complete list of eligible respondents for the study. All findings were carefully reviewed to avoid potential bias or error, and no limitations were identified in the study.

I. Transparency and Honest in Reporting

The study's findings will be reported honestly, with no manipulation or alteration of the data. All sources, including academic references, were cited correctly and acknowledged to ensure respect for intellectual property rights and uphold ethical research standards. This study utilized some AI tools to support various aspects of the research. There was no potential conflict of interest involved in the study.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials

No patented materials were involved in this study. All copyrighted materials, including references, will be appropriately cited in accordance with intellectual property

laws. The researchers ensured that all sources were appropriately acknowledged, maintaining academic integrity and avoiding plagiarism.

K. Ethical Considerations for Animal and Human Trials

The researchers will inform respondents about the possible risks and potential benefits of the study and will ensure that an informed consent form is provided. If any significant risks are identified, such as emotional, physical, or psychological, appropriate health monitoring programs and emotional support services will be available.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Related technology

The researchers used digital technologies throughout the research process, including finding reliable articles to maintain the study's accuracy and credibility. AI tools, such as ChatGPT, were utilized to assist in summarizing statements and enhancing the quality of the study. Platforms such as Google Scholar, Elicit, and Typeset.io were used to identify supporting studies, thereby ensuring the research's reliability and credibility. Additionally, Grammarly was used to ensure the research report met proper grammar and clarity standards. The responsible use of technologies helped maintain the integrity of the study.

M. Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval



The research obtained ethical approval from the Institutional Review Board of Saint Michael College of Caraga, confirming its compliance with all relevant guidelines on the protection of respondents, data privacy, and intellectual property rights.

2.6 Data Gathering Procedure

The researchers first sent a request letter to the Office of the School Registrar of Saint Michael College of Caraga to obtain the list of graduates who served as respondents. This request was verified by the Office of the Dean of the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management (CTHM). The list was then submitted to the Statistician to confirm the number of respondents. After confirming the respondents, the researchers will prepare survey questionnaire and submit it to the research adviser and selected experts for content validation. After validation, the instrument will undergo pilot testing. The pilot test results will then be submitted to the Statistician for reliability testing and confirmation of the instrument's consistency. After completing the validation and pilot testing, a formal request to conduct the study and administer the questionnaire will be submitted to the Office of the Dean (CTHM), for final approval. Upon approval, the researchers will distribute the questionnaires to the qualified respondents and collect the accomplished forms. The gathered data will be tallied and submitted again to the Statistician for verification before the researchers proceed with data analysis and interpretation.

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